

Notes and Exercises from *Computability, Complexity, and Languages* by Martin D. Davis et al.

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Chapter 2: Programs and Computable Functions

Section 1. A Programming Language

Notes

The first programming language that is defined is pretty simple. It only has the following parts

$V \leftarrow V + 1$	Increment	
$V \leftarrow V - 1$	Decrement*	1
IF $V \neq 0$ GOTO A	Conditional Branch	

* If $V = 0$ then keep $V = 0$.

Actually there are no negative numbers, they only kind of numbers the program works for are just in $\mathbb{N}$. Also for convention they call the input variables $X_1, X_2, X_3, \dots$ and the output variables $Y_1, Y_2, Y_3, \dots$ and local variables $Z_1, Z_2, Z_3, \dots$ often dropping the subscript.

X	Input	
Y	Output	2
Z	Local	

Also instructions are optionally “labelled” using the following notation.

$$A_1, B_1, C_1, D_1, E_1, A_2, B_2, C_2, D_2, E_2, A_3, \dots \quad 3$$

Once again often with the subscript dropped. E is often the label of the “exit” instruction, meaning it has no instructions and halts the program. Also instructions must be finite. Additionally local and output variables are initialized to 0. Finally this programming language is designated $\mathcal{L}$.

Section 2. Some Examples of Programs

Notes

Abbreviating a “pseudo”-instruction or set of instructions is called a *Macro* and the following is an example of a common one.

$$\text{GOTO } [L] \quad 4$$

Where the IF part of the conditional branch is omitted. Another common macro that is seen a lot is

$$V \leftarrow V' \quad 5$$

where the V' is replaced by some other variable during the *macro expansion*. Here the books works hard to show how this assignment/initialization takes place and what the expansion

looks like. As a mathematician it seems pretty simple that I can initialize a variable to whatever I want it to be, including outputs of functions on variables denoted $+$, $-$, $\times$, $\dots$, but it is cool to see how these abstractions occur in the language $\mathcal{L}$.

Exercises

1. Write a program in $\mathcal{L}$ that computes the function $f(x) = 3x$.

Solution

	$Y \leftarrow X$ $Z \leftarrow 2$ $\left. \begin{array}{l} \text{IF } Y \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A \\ \text{GOTO } E \end{array} \right] \text{ Unnecessary}$	6
[A]	$Y \leftarrow X + Y$ $Z \leftarrow Z - 1$ $\text{IF } Z \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A$	

2. Write a program in $\mathcal{L}$ that solves Exercise 1 using no macros.

I am not gonna do this one since you can just fill in the macros.

3. Let $f(x) = 1$ if x is even; $f(x) = 0$ if x is odd. Write a program in $\mathcal{L}$ that computes f .

	$[C] \quad \text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A$ $\text{GOTO } E$	
[A]	$X \leftarrow X - 1$ $Y = Y + 1$ $\text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } B$ $\text{GOTO } E$	7
[B]	$X \leftarrow X - 1$ $Y = Y - 1$ $\text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A$	

4. Let $f(x) = 1$ if x is even; $f(x)$ undefined if x is odd. Write a program in $\mathcal{L}$ that computes f .

	$Y \leftarrow 1$ $[C] \quad \text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A$ $\text{GOTO } E$	
[A]	$X \leftarrow X - 1$ $\text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } B$ $\text{GOTO } A$	8
[B]	$X \leftarrow X - 1$ $\text{IF } X \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } A$	

Section 3. Syntax

Notes

This section is a bit of repetition as well as a very detailed account of the language $\mathcal{L}$, so I will have brief notes.

The following are called *statements*

$$\begin{aligned} V &\leftarrow V + 1 \\ V &\leftarrow V - 1 \\ V &\leftarrow V \\ \text{IF } V \neq 0 \text{ GOTO } L \end{aligned} \tag{9}$$

where V may be any variable and L may be any label. An *instruction* is either a statement or a label-statement pair. A *program* is a list (finite sequence) of instructions. The length of the list is the *length* of a program. The *empty program* is the program of length 0.

The *state of a program* $\mathcal{P}$ is a list of equations of the form $V = m$, where V is a variable and m is a number, including an equation for each variable that occurs in $\mathcal{P}$ and including no two equations with the same variable.

Let σ be a state of $\mathcal{P}$ and let V be a variable that occurs in σ . The *value of V at σ* is then the number q such that the equation $V = q$ is one of the equations making up σ . The *snapshot* or *instantaneous description* of a program $\mathcal{P}$ of length n is the pair (i, σ) where i is the instruction about to be executed and $1 \leq i \leq n + 1$ and σ is a state of $\mathcal{P}$. $i = n + 1$ is the “stop” instruction.

Page 27 defines all the cases of a *successor* of a snapshot.

A *computation* of a program $\mathcal{P}$ is a list

$$s_1, s_2, s_3, \dots, s_k \tag{10}$$

s_i snapshots of $\mathcal{P}$, such that s_{i+1} is the successor of s_i for $i = 1, 2, 3, \dots, k - 1$ and s_k is *terminal*, meaning $i = n + 1$.

Exercises

1. Give a program $\mathcal{P}$ that such that for every computation $s_1, s_2, \dots, s_k$ of $\mathcal{P}$, $k = 5$.

Solution

$$\begin{aligned} Z &\leftarrow 0 \\ Z &\leftarrow Z + 1 \\ Z &\leftarrow Z + 1 \\ Z &\leftarrow Z + 1 \end{aligned} \tag{11}$$

Section 4. Computable Functions